

TIGON DESIGN DOCTRINE — A Truth-of-Source Guide for a Premium Digital Agency Website

Purpose: A permanent reference for building Tigon.no — a principled framework, not a rigid template. Opinionated, concrete, and built for a Next.js / plain CSS / GSAP / Framer Motion / Lenis stack. Brutal honesty throughout: where your past sites failed, it was almost certainly a lack of *intention*, not a lack of *effects*.

TL;DR

- **The "awwwards feeling" is not effects — it's authored pacing.** Award sites win on Design (40%), Usability (30%), Creativity (20%), Content (10%) per Awwwards' published jury system. What separates them from "AI slop" is that every section is a distinct *moment* with one idea, one focal point, deliberate contrast, and motion that serves narrative rather than decorating it.
 - **Your seven sections must each feel structurally different** while sharing one type/space/color system. Vary layout archetype, dark/light rhythm, and motion role section-by-section so the scroll feels like a journey with tension and release — not a stack of identical blocks.
 - **Restraint is the differentiator.** One workhorse typeface + one accent, a strict spacing scale, a near-monochrome palette with a single disciplined accent, and strong ease-out motion under ~300ms. Premium is defined by what you refuse to add.
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Key Findings

1. **Awwwards is scored, not vibed.** Sites are judged by a minimum of 18 jurors on Design 40% / Usability 30% / Creativity 20% / Content 10%, with the 3 outlier scores dropped and a 5-day vote (verbatim from Awwwards' About-Evaluation page). Site of the Day needs roughly an 8.0+ average; Honorable Mention requires a jury score of 6.5 or higher. Most submissions fail on *usability*, not creativity. Custom interaction design is repeatedly cited as the single biggest differentiator between winners and template/AI sites.
2. **The best studios think like editors, not decorators.** Obys (Studio of the Year 2023 by Awwwards; 4× Studio of the Year — 2020, 2021, 2023, 2024 — by CSS Design Awards; intentionally small team) states verbatim: "we often approach websites the way editors approach long-form publications. A good editorial piece is not just a collection of paragraphs. It has tension. It has contrast. It has silence between strong statements." Their rule: "You can break the grid only if you understand it." Active Theory frames it as "designing foundations that last," not "designing moments." [Codrops](#) [LBBOOnline](#)
3. **"AI slop" has specific, nameable tells:** identical padding/border-radius/card-heights everywhere, generic averaged headlines ("Empowering teams to build better products"),

default fonts (Inter/Roboto), purple-on-white gradients, and effects with no narrative reason. The antidote is specificity and intentional variation.

4. **Motion has premium numbers.** Strong ease-out curves, durations generally under ~300ms for UI/reveals, and tight staggers (0.02–0.08s). "The built-in easing curves in CSS are usually not strong enough, which is why I almost never use them" (Emil Kowalski, animations.dev) — premium work uses custom curves like `easeOutExpo(cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1))`.
 5. **Restraint is trending harder than maximalism for credibility.** The "human touch is found in the restraint. Choosing not to use a feature is now a more powerful design statement than adding one." Over-animation actively hurts: "A LOT of elements should actually be static."
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Details

PART 1 — DISSECTING THE THREE REFERENCE SITES

A. lessestudio.com — "Editorial restraint + tactile craft"

Layout & rhythm. Lesse is a design/technology studio in Italy. The homepage runs a classic premium arc: hero statement → an interactive *services* accordion (expandable list where each service reveals sub-services and imagery) → approach/values → "Latest Work" case cards → testimonials → journal. The power move is the **services list-as-interaction**: instead of a boring grid of cards, services are a vertical editorial list that expands, giving the page a hierarchy of "one thing at a time."

Typography. Large, confident sans headings with tight tracking against small, quiet labels ("01 / 03 Brand Identity"). The doubling of headings ("Our services Our services") is a marquee/scroll-reveal device, not a typo — text is treated as a graphic object.

Color & contrast. Predominantly light, gallery-white canvas with black type and full-bleed imagery providing the color. This is the "let the work be the color" strategy — the studio's own chrome stays neutral so client work pops.

Motion. Restrained scroll reveals, hover-driven expansion on the services list, smooth momentum scroll. Nothing moves that doesn't respond to intent.

Reusable principles: (1) Turn a list into an interaction. (2) Numbered labels ("01/03") create a sense of editorial sequence. (3) Neutral studio chrome + colorful work imagery.

B. fabrica.framer.media — "Confident type + numbered narrative + monochrome"

Layout & rhythm. Fabrica is a Framer template studio site by Anatolii Dmitrienko. It is the clearest template for Tigon because it uses the exact device you need: **numbered sections** — (001) through (004) services, plus a strong "Why choose us," stats counters (0+, 0%), projects list with years ((Boltshift./2025)), testimonials, team, FAQ, contact. Each section is announced with a tiny eyebrow label ("What we do / Services.") and a number.

Typography. A grotesque display face set very large for section titles ("Projects.", "Services.", "Experiences.") with a period as a full-stop graphic device — this single punctuation habit gives the whole site a confident editorial voice. Body copy is small, quiet, high-contrast. The size jump between the section title and the eyebrow label is large (a high-contrast type scale).

Color & contrast. Monochrome base (near-black text on white, plus dark gradient "moments" — the About and CTA sections use a dark gradient background image). This is **dark/light section alternation as a rhythm device**: most sections are light, and the dark gradient sections act as punctuation and tonal shift.

Motion. Animated stat counters (0→target), scroll reveals, marquee client logos, hover states on project rows. Restrained and purposeful.

Reusable principles: (1) Number your sections — it literally creates the "journey." (2) The period-after-title device (Services.) is free confidence. (3) Alternate mostly-light sections with occasional dark gradient "moments." (4) A big type-scale gap between eyebrow and title.

C. effica.framer.ai — "Numbered scroll-story + sticky/pinned moments"

Layout & rhythm. Effica (AI consulting template, also by Dmitrienko) is the most "journey"-driven of the three. It uses an explicit **numbered progression 01→13** as the spine of the entire page: 01 Who we are, 02 Services, 03 Why us, 04 Easy first step, 05 How we do it, 06 Results/case study, 07 Team, 08 Why us, 10 What we believe (with a founding timeline 2020→2025), 11 News, 12 FAQ, 13 Get in touch. This is a masterclass in **making a long page feel like chapters**. framer

Typography. Big confident headings, lowercase section eyebrows ("how we work", "who we are"), numeric hashtags (#AIConsulting, #SaveTime) used as texture/metadata. Stat displays ("50+ hours saved monthly", "+15% retention") are treated as typographic focal points. framer

Color & contrast. Dark-leaning, with restrained accents and heavy use of numbered chapter markers.

Motion. Scroll-triggered reveals per chapter, a "2:30" video moment, staggered service list. The numbers pin the reader's sense of place.

Reusable principles: (1) A visible numbered index (01→N) is the single most effective "journey" device — it's why all three references feel authored. (2) Data/stats as hero-scale type. (3) A brand timeline is a great "philosophy/belief" section format.

The synthesis across all three: none rely on heavy WebGL or gimmicks. They win on **numbered editorial structure, huge confident type against tiny labels, monochrome-plus-restraint, dark/light punctuation, and motion that only reveals — never distracts**. That is directly achievable in your stack.

PART 2 — WHAT WINS AWWWARDS / FWA / CSSDA (2025-2026)

The scoring reality. Awwwards: minimum 18 jurors, Design 40% / Usability 30% / Creativity

20% / Content 10%, outlier scores dropped, 5-day vote, ~8.0+ average for Site of the Day (6.5+ for Honorable Mention), and — as Awwwards itself frames the scarcity — "there's only 365 days in a year, not everyone who deserves a SOTD will win one." Performance (Core Web Vitals) feeds the usability score. Judges test navigation by clicking through without guidance — **usability is where most entries die, not creativity.** (Utsubo + 2)

What judges reward (recurring patterns):

- **Custom interaction design** — the single biggest differentiator; template and AI-generated sites are immediately recognizable to experienced judges. (Utsubo)
- **Storytelling and art direction** — repeatedly named as what turns a checklist-perfect site into an award-winner.
- **Bold, confident typography** — judges form impressions "within seconds" from type. (Slider Revolution)
- **Micro-interactions and considered detail** — "microinteractions and randomness are essential to make a website stand out." (Medium)
- **Technical craft** — WebGL/Three.js/WebGPU dominate the very top tier: the 2025 Awwwards **Site of the Year was the Lando Norris site by Scottish studio OFF+BRAND** (SOTD Nov 17, 2025), and **Developer Site of the Year was "Messenger" by abeto** — "a tiny WebGL planet, brought to life in your browser" (voting closed January 2026). But this is not required — solo designers and minimal sites win SOTD regularly. (Slider Revolution)

The studios, decoded:

- **Active Theory** — WebGL-first immersive experiences (Hydra framework); philosophy shifted toward "designing foundations that last," experiences "with intention."
- **Locomotive** — Awwwards Agency/Studio of the Year; "meaningful, innovative, results-driven digital experiences." (Awwwards)
- **Obys** — Studio of the Year 2023 (Awwwards) + 4× CSS Design Awards Studio of the Year (2020, 2021, 2023, 2024); rooted in Swiss/modernist graphic design — "typography, grid systems, composition, hierarchy"; treats sites as long-form editorial with tension and contrast; intentionally small team (<10). (Obys Agency)
- **Basement Studio, Unseen Studio, Studio Freight (now Darkroom, makers of Lenis)** — narrative-driven, motion-rich, editorial sensibility.

The transferable lesson: the award-winning agency aesthetic = **modernist graphic-design fundamentals (grid, type, hierarchy) + narrative structure + restrained, custom motion + flawless usability/performance.** Not effects for their own sake.

PART 3 — INTENTIONAL DESIGN VS. "AI SLOP"

The core distinction: *design intent means every choice has a reason.* AI/template output "looks good because AI understands visual patterns. But it feels generic because patterns alone are

not enough." The mechanism behind AI slop is **distributional convergence** — a model defaults to the statistical center of everything it has seen, so it produces "the safe design choices that work universally," which is exactly what makes it feel generic. (Medium) (Superdesign)

The nameable tells of slop:

- Identical padding, identical border-radius, identical card heights throughout — "when every element gets the same 16px border radius and 24px padding, the page feels flat and undifferentiated." (925Studios)
- Averaged, meaningless headlines. Compare to Stripe's "Financial infrastructure for the internet" or Linear's "Plan and build products." **Specificity is the antidote to slop.**
- Default fonts (Inter/Roboto everywhere), purple-on-white gradients, glossy-but-hollow hero blobs.
- Effects with no narrative reason.

What makes design feel human-authored:

1. **Editorial / art-direction thinking** — decide the story first, then rank content by importance ("if the reader only looks at one thing, what should it be?"), then design contrast around that. (Pangram Pangram)
2. **Constraint and restraint** — "The best products (Linear, Notion, Stripe) are distinctive because of restraint, not excess. They make fewer design choices, but each choice is intentional and consistent." A single strong opinion (one loud color, one bold type choice, one uncommon layout) beats a pile of safe ones.
3. **Meaningful contrast** — real design systems "create visual hierarchy through intentional variation," not uniformity. (925Studios)
4. **Deliberate imperfection & custom choices** — a custom font, a real photograph, an asymmetric layout, an odd but intentional grid break. "Break the grid only if you understand it" (Obys). (Codrops)
5. **Typographic craft** — deliberate scale jumps, tracking, one-family discipline.
6. **"Designing a journey" vs. "adding effects"** — the difference between choreographing pacing/tension and sprinkling animations on a static page.

The brutal-honesty diagnosis of your past sites: if they felt like "no journey, little variation, no wow," the causes are almost always (a) every section used the same layout archetype and same padding, (b) no numbered/editorial spine to create sequence, (c) type scale too timid (no huge moments), (d) motion decorated instead of revealing, and (e) no dark/light rhythm. All five are fixed below.

PART 4 — THE CONCRETE DESIGN SYSTEM

4.1 Typographic system

Font strategy — one workhorse + one accent. The premium-agency default is a neo-grotesque workhorse. **PP Neue Montreal** is the fan-favorite here — described by its foundry Pangram Pangram as "neutral enough to function as a reliable workhorse, yet expressive enough to bring subtle character to any layout," with a "full weight axis, from Hairline to Black" and a dedicated Text-Size cut for body. Pair it with a high-contrast editorial serif for occasional display moments — **PP Editorial New** is the canonical partner ("modern efficiency and classic sophistication"). Alternatives/free stand-ins: Inter or Geist for UI body, but push past defaults for display. Rule: **one workhorse family across the whole site; one accent/display face used surgically** for hero or section titles only. A monospace (e.g., a Mono cut) is optional as a third, narrow-task voice for labels/metadata/numbers — which fits your numbered-section concept perfectly. (Pangram Pangram)

Type scale — go high-contrast. For an art-directed agency site, use a **dramatic ratio**: Perfect Fourth (1.333), Perfect Fifth (1.5), or Golden Ratio (1.618) for the display steps. A tighter 1.2-1.25 (Minor/Major Third) is fine for UI/body steps. Best practice is **two scales in one system**: a wider ratio for editorial/hero type, a tighter ratio for UI. Example at 16px base, 1.25: Body 16 / H6 20 / H5 25 / H4 31 / H3 39 / H2 49 / H1 61. For hero moments, break the scale deliberately and go huge (display 80-160px+).

Fluid type with clamp(). Use `clamp()` for display headings, but anchor the middle value in `rem + vw` (not pure `vw`) so browser zoom still works — pure `vw` fails WCAG zoom. Example: `--fs-hero: clamp(2.5rem, 2rem + 3vw, 5rem)`. Don't build the *entire* system on clamp — keep body text on discrete, predictable steps. (Piccalilli)

Weight & size contrast. Contrast is created by **size AND weight AND case** — not one dimension. A common premium pattern: tiny uppercase eyebrow label (12-14px, wide tracking, medium weight) sitting above a huge display title (Medium/Bold). "Structure carries voice better than novelty." (Studio Ubique)

Line-height & tracking rules.

- Body: line-height 1.4-1.7 (loosen for long-form). (Studio Ubique)
- Large display headings: tighten to 1.0-1.15.
- Line length: 45-85 characters (`max-width: ~65ch`). (Studio Ubique)
- Tracking: tighten large display type slightly (negative letter-spacing, e.g. -0.01 to -0.03em); open up small uppercase labels (+0.05 to +0.15em).
- Contrast target: WCAG AA — 4.5:1 body, 3:1 large text. (Toptal) (Studio Ubique)

When to go huge: exactly once or twice per page — the hero, and maybe one philosophy/statement moment. If everything is huge, nothing is. Hugeness is a *focal-point tool*, not a default.

4.2 Spacing & rhythm

Use an 8pt grid (with 4pt half-steps for tight typographic adjustments). Multiples of 8: 8/16/24/32/40/48/56/64/80/96/128. Define as CSS custom properties / tokens so there is one source of truth:

CSS

```
:root{
  --space-1:8px; --space-2:16px; --space-3:24px; --space-4:32px;
  --space-6:48px; --space-8:64px; --space-12:96px; --space-16:128px;
}
```

The internal ≤ external rule (Gestalt proximity): padding inside an element should be ≤ the spacing separating it from neighbors, so groups read as distinct. This single rule fixes most "cheap/untrustworthy" layouts. (Cieden)

Section padding philosophy — this is where premium is won or lost. Generous vertical section padding is the number-one signal of a premium feel: "Clean, spacious layouts feel more premium." Use large section padding (e.g. `--space-16`)/128px+ top and bottom on desktop, scaling down fluidly on mobile). **Vary padding to control pace:** tighter spacing = urgency/energy; wider spacing = slows the scroll and adds gravitas. Do not use identical section padding everywhere — that's a slop tell. Let the "philosophy" moment breathe with extra space; let a dense services list run tighter. (HUEMOR)

Whitespace = framing, not emptiness. "Whitespace isn't what you leave out, it's how you frame what matters." Surround your single most important element per section (CTA, statement) with disproportionate space. (HUEMOR)

4.3 Layout & grid

- **Establish a 12-column grid** with a container max-width (~1200-1440px) and generous side margins (~5-8vw). This is your baseline order.
- **Then break it intentionally.** Asymmetry creates the "energy" symmetry lacks. Rules for breaking: (1) find one focal point per section — "everything can't be equally important"; (2) balance by *visual weight*, not mirroring (large image offset by a cluster of small elements); (3) use negative space as the counterweight; (4) keep an underlying grid so it reads as intentional, not chaotic. (Medium + 2)
- **Full-bleed vs. contained:** full-bleed for imagery, dark "moment" sections, and hero; contained for reading/editorial content. Alternating the two is itself a rhythm device.
- **Column strategy:** vary it per section — a single centered column (statement), a 2-col split (image/text), an offset 5/7 asymmetric split, a wide multi-column list. Variety of column structure is a primary tool for section distinctiveness (Part 4.8).

4.4 Color & contrast

Build a restrained, near-monochrome palette. Premium agency = discipline, not rainbow. Structure it as **semantic tokens by role**, not raw hex: `--color-bg`, `--color-surface`, `--color-text`, `--color-text-muted`, `--color-border`, `--color-accent`.

A dark-mode-capable premium base (example):

- Canvas: near-black (■ #0E0E0E)–(■ #121212) (avoid pure (■ #000) for large areas; reduces halation) OR gallery-white (□ #FAFAF9). (Colorhero) (Colorffy)
- Text: off-white (□ #E8E8E8)/(□ #F5F5F5) on dark (never pure (■ #FFF) on true black — eye strain); near-black on light. (DEV Community) (Muzli)
- Muted text: a mid-grey ((■ #A1A1AA)-ish) for labels/metadata.
- Surfaces: step 4–8% lighter than canvas for cards; borders 6–10% lighter. (Theme & Color)

Accent discipline — the single most important color rule. One accent color, used *surgically* on interactive states, key highlights, and one or two brand moments. "That same color splashed across backgrounds, borders, text highlights, and decorative elements looks like a theme from a free template site. Restraint is the design." Linear "uses it surgically on interactive states and barely anywhere else." On dark, accents usually need reduced chroma + adjusted luminance to avoid vibration; define separate text-accent vs. fill-accent tokens. (Seedflip + 2)

Dark/light alternation as rhythm (the Fabrica move). Most sections light (or most dark), with occasional inverted "moments" as punctuation and tonal shift. This is one of the most effective journey devices and costs nothing. Map both themes to the *same token names* so components never hard-code hex. (Muzli)

Contrast for hierarchy: the brightest/highest-contrast element in a section should be its focal point. Muted everything else.

4.5 Visual hierarchy

- **One thing per section.** Each section states one idea, has one clear focal point, and one primary action. This is the antidote to "no journey" — it makes each section a *moment*.
- **Guide the eye** with scale contrast (huge title vs. tiny label), position (focal point at a rule-of-thirds intersection), and isolation (whitespace around the hero element).
- **Three levels of hierarchy minimum** (heading / subhead / body), plus metadata (labels, numbers, captions) as a distinct quiet tier.
- **Squint test:** zoom out, squint — can you tell what matters most in each section in under a second? If not, increase contrast of the focal element and mute the rest.

4.6 Motion & animation doctrine

Governing principle: motion **supports narrative** (reveals, guides, gives feedback, reinforces brand) or it is deleted. "Every element moving on a page is mental 'bandwidth' you take away." "A LOT of elements should actually be static — by not animating them you'll get better time-on-page, lower bounce rates." (Clutch)

Easing — use custom curves; built-in CSS easings are too weak. Per Emil Kowalski (animations.dev): "The built-in easing curves in CSS are usually not strong enough, which is why I almost never use them."

- **Entrances / reveals / most UI:** strong ease-out. Premium values: `easeOutExpo` (`cubic-bezier(0.16, 1, 0.3, 1)`), `easeOutQuint` (`cubic-bezier(0.22, 1, 0.36, 1)`) (both

confirmed via easings.net), or Kowalski's published **strong ease-out** `cubic-bezier(0.23, 1, 0.32, 1)`. In GSAP: `power2.out` is the versatile default, `power3.out`/`power4.out`/`expo.out` for stronger, more dramatic reveals. Strength order: Sine < Quad < Cubic < Quart < Quint < Expo. [FWD Tools + 3](#)

- **On-screen movement / things that enter and exit:** strong ease-in-out — Kowalski's `cubic-bezier(0.77, 0, 0.175, 1)`, or Material Design 3 "emphasized" `cubic-bezier(0.2, 0, 0, 1)`. [GitHub](#)
- **Drawers / panels (iOS feel):** Kowalski's `cubic-bezier(0.32, 0.72, 0, 1)`.
- **Never use `ease-in` for UI** (Kowalski): "It starts slow... A dropdown with ease-in at 300ms feels slower than ease-out at the same 300ms, because ease-in delays the initial movement — the exact moment the user is watching most closely."
- **Never `linear`** except marquees, progress/time indicators, and constant rotations. [Animations on the Web](#)
- **Overshoot** (`easeOutBack cubic-bezier(0.34, 1.56, 0.64, 1)`) only for playful spring-settle on small elements (rare on a premium agency site). [FWD Tools](#)

Duration guidelines.

- Micro-interactions / hovers / button feedback: **100-200ms**.
- Entrances / reveals: keep under ~300ms where possible — Kowalski: "UI animations should generally stay under 300ms... A 180ms dropdown feels more responsive than a 400ms one." Reserve 300-500ms for larger content reveals.
- Large transitions / page/section changes: **400-600ms max** — beyond ~1s feels like a delay.
- Material Design corroboration: micro 50-200ms, content 200-400ms, complex 400-600ms; exits slightly faster than entrances. [Riad Kilani](#) [Material Design](#)

Stagger. For list/grid reveals, **0.02-0.08s between items** (tighter ~0.02 for dense lists, 0.05-0.08 for cards/hero grids). In GSAP use `ScrollTrigger.batch()` + `stagger`; in Framer Motion use `staggerChildren`. Optionally stagger `from:"center"` or `"edges"` for grids.

[ICS MEDIA](#) [ICS MEDIA](#)

Scroll-triggered reveals (the core technique). Reveal on enter with `start: "top 85%"`, small `y` offset (30-60px) + opacity, strong ease-out, `once: true` for content (don't re-animate on scroll-back). For text, character/line splits read more premium than a whole-block fade.

[Gsapify](#)

Scrubbed / pinned moments (use sparingly — 1-2 per page). Pin a section and scrub an animation to scroll for a genuine "moment" (a statement that assembles, an image that scales, a horizontal-scroll gallery). GSAP `pin: true, scrub: 1`. **Warning:** never animate the pinned element itself (animate children); `pin: true` creates a pin-spacer that frequently breaks on mobile (dynamic viewport height) — test on real devices and consider disabling pins under a breakpoint via `gsap.matchMedia()`. [GreenSock](#) [Annnimate](#)

Parallax: subtle only (background/foreground at slightly different speeds). Aggressive parallax "works against the user."

Smooth scroll (Lenis). Lenis wraps native scroll so `position: sticky`, anchor links, and accessibility keep working. Integrate with GSAP by driving `lenis.raf` from `gsap.ticker` and calling `ScrollTrigger.update` on Lenis scroll, with `gsap.ticker.lagSmoothing(0)`:

```
js

const lenis = new Lenis({ lerp: 0.1 }); // ~0.08-0.1 balances smoothness/responsiveness
lenis.on('scroll', ScrollTrigger.update);
gsap.ticker.add(t => lenis.raf(t*1000));
gsap.ticker.lagSmoothing(0);
```

Keep `lerp` around 0.08–0.1; don't over-smooth (disconnected, "floaty" feel and higher CPU). Disable smoothing on touch by default. In Next.js, initialize client-side (`'use client'`, `useEffect`/`useGSAP`) and clean up on unmount/route change. [DeepWiki](#)

Hover microinteractions. Buttons: subtle background/color transition on `ease` at 150–200ms + a small scale-down on press. Links: animated underline (clip/scaleX from left). Project rows: image peek / cursor-follow / row highlight. Cards: slight lift + border/surface lightening (4–8%). Keep them consistent — random per-element hover behavior "makes your site feel unprofessional."

Accessibility — non-negotiable. Respect `prefers-reduced-motion`: skip ScrollTrigger setups or set Lenis `lerp: 1` (instant) for those users. It matters for accessibility *and* Core Web Vitals (which feed the Awwwards usability score).

4.7 The "journey" / narrative principle

Think of the page as a piece of music or a film edit: **tension and release, loud and quiet, fast and slow.**

- **Give the page a visible spine.** The single most effective journey device (and the shared secret of all three references) is a **numbered section index** (01→07). Number your sections. It instantly turns a stack of blocks into chapters.
- **Pace with space and tempo.** Alternate dense sections (services list, tight padding, fast staggers) with sparse "breath" sections (a single centered statement, huge padding, slow reveal). Contrast in *rhythm* is what makes each section feel distinct.
- **Each section is a "moment":** one idea, one focal point, its own layout archetype, and a motion role that differs from its neighbors.
- **Transitions between sections** should feel authored: the dark/light flip, a color/gradient bleed from one section into the next, a pinned hand-off, or a shared element that carries across. Avoid hard, unrelated cuts.
- **Build to a release.** The Philosophy/System section is your emotional peak (biggest type, most space, maybe a pinned moment); How-we-work resolves it into concrete process;

the footer/contact is the exhale + call to action.

4.8 Section-variety toolkit (tailored to Tigon's 7-section arc)

Assign each section a **distinct layout archetype + motion role + tonal value** so monotony is structurally impossible:

- **01 Hero.** Full-bleed, single centered or left-aligned huge display statement (break the type scale here — 80-160px). Motion: a considered entrance (line-split reveal, or a subtle scrubbed/looping background). Tone: set your dominant theme (say, dark). One focal statement + one CTA. Avoid generic "we build digital experiences" copy — be specific like Stripe/Linear.
- **02 Approach / Tilnærming.** Editorial 2-column or offset asymmetric split (statement left, supporting text/visual right). Motion: quiet scroll reveal, stagger on sub-points. Tone: flip to light for contrast with hero. This is a "breath" section — generous padding.
- **03 What we build / Hva vi bygger.** Interactive **list-as-interaction** (the Lesse move): a vertical list of capabilities that expand/reveal on hover, or a bento/asymmetric grid. Motion: hover expansion + `ScrollTrigger.batch` staggered reveal. Tone: could stay light. Denser, tighter rhythm.
- **04 What we improve / Hva vi forbedrer.** Deliberately *different* from 03 — use a **before/after, metric-driven, or horizontal-scroll** treatment. Stats as hero-scale type (the Effic move). Motion: animated counters, maybe one pinned horizontal-scroll moment. Tone: consider a dark "moment" here for punctuation.
- **05 Philosophy / System / Filosofi.** The emotional peak. **Full-screen break**, minimal, biggest statement type, maximum whitespace, possibly a **pinned/scrubbed** assembly of a manifesto line, or a brand timeline (the Effic belief-timeline format). Motion: slow, deliberate, the most cinematic moment on the site. Tone: strong tonal shift (invert).
- **06 How we work / Slik jobber vi.** Process = **numbered steps** (01→N) — a stepped list, sticky-scroll walkthrough, or pinned step reveal. Motion: step-by-step scroll-linked reveals. Tone: resolve back toward the base theme. Structured, orderly, calmer than the philosophy peak.
- **07 Footer / Contact.** Large, confident closing statement + a single clear CTA, generous space (the exhale). Consider a big animated wordmark, a marquee, or an oversized email link with a hover microinteraction. Tone: mirror the hero to bookend the journey.

Rule: no two adjacent sections should share the same (layout archetype + tonal value + motion role). If two neighbors feel similar, change one of those three axes.

PART 5 — PRINCIPLES OF RESTRAINT

- **Premium is defined by refusal.** "The best products are distinctive because of restraint, not excess... fewer design choices, but each intentional and consistent." Every element must earn its place. (925Studios)

- **The danger of over-animating is real and measurable.** Animating everything distracts, raises bounce, and hurts conversion; "if an animation doesn't add to the experience, it's better to leave it out." Fast/aggressive motion also harms motion-sensitive users. Default many elements to **static**.
 - **Coherence over novelty.** One workhorse type family, one accent, one spacing scale, one easing set, one motion vocabulary. Novelty within a coherent system reads as confident; novelty everywhere reads as noise. "Random or inconsistent animations make your site feel unprofessional."
 - **Constraint enables creativity.** Obys: "Freedom without structure is noise. You can break the grid only if you understand it." Define the system rigorously, *then* break it deliberately at chosen focal moments — that deliberate break is what reads as authored. (Codrops)
 - **Keeping the system flexible without becoming inconsistent:** enforce the *tokens* (space, type scale, color roles, easing, durations) as the fixed, non-negotiable layer; leave *composition* (layout archetype, which element is huge, where you break the grid, which sections invert) as the free, creative layer. Consistency lives in the tokens; creativity lives in the composition. That's how you get an award-level, cohesive site that still surprises section to section.
 - **Minimalism is currently the *stronger* differentiator against AI.** "The human touch is found in the restraint. Choosing not to use a feature is now a more powerful design statement than adding one." In a sea of over-produced AI slop, a disciplined, confident, quiet-but-bold site is what stops the scroll. (Xdcweb)
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Recommendations

Stage 1 — Build the fixed system first (before any layout). Lock tokens in CSS custom properties: type scale (pick a workhorse like PP Neue Montreal + one display/serif accent; set a two-ratio scale), 8pt spacing scale, semantic color roles (near-monochrome + one accent, dark/light themes on shared token names), easing set (`--ease-out: cubic-bezier(0.16,1,0.3,1);` `--ease-inout: cubic-bezier(0.77,0,0.175,1)`), and duration tokens (`--dur-micro:150ms; --dur-reveal:300ms; --dur-large:600ms`). *Benchmark to proceed:* you can build any section using only these tokens.

Stage 2 — Script the journey on paper. Write the 7 sections as a numbered storyboard. For each, define: the one idea, the one focal point, the layout archetype, the tonal value (dark/light), and the motion role. *Threshold that forces a redo:* if any two adjacent sections share layout+tone+motion, change one axis.

Stage 3 — Build static-first, then layer motion. Get the whole page looking premium with *zero* animation (type, space, hierarchy, contrast, dark/light rhythm carry it). Only then add motion — reveals first, then 1-2 pinned/scrubbed "moments," then hover microinteractions. *Benchmark:* if the static page doesn't already feel premium, motion won't save it — go back to type scale and spacing.

Stage 4 — Add the numbered spine + one signature moment. Number the sections (01→07). Pick exactly one section (likely 05 Philosophy) for a genuine cinematic pinned/scrubbed moment. Resist adding a second showpiece.

Stage 5 — Integrate Lenis + GSAP correctly, then harden. Wire Lenis to the GSAP ticker (`(lerp) ~0.08-0.1, (lagSmoothing(0))`), respect `(prefers-reduced-motion)`, disable pins under a mobile breakpoint via `(matchMedia)`, and test scroll on real devices. *Benchmark to ship:* Core Web Vitals green (feeds Awwwards usability), 60fps scroll, no pin-spacer gaps on mobile, and navigable via keyboard.

Ongoing benchmarks that would change your choices:

- If a section fails the *squint test* (focal point not obvious in 1s) → increase focal contrast, mute the rest.
 - If the page feels monotonous → you've violated section-variety; change layout/tone/motion on the offending neighbors, or your padding is uniform (vary it).
 - If it feels "busy/cheap" → you've over-animated or over-accented; cut motion to reveals-only and restrict the accent to interactive states.
 - If it feels "flat/AI" → type scale is too timid (add a huge moment), copy is generic (make it specific), and/or spacing is uniform.
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Caveats

- **Framer template caveat:** `fabrica.framer.media` and `effica.framer.ai` are commercial Framer *templates* (both by Anatolii Dmitrienko), not bespoke award-winners. They're excellent structural references (numbering, type confidence, dark/light rhythm) but reference them for *structure and restraint*, not for originality — copying a template's exact look would itself read as generic.
- **WebGL is not required.** Top-tier Awwwards Site-of-the-Year winners increasingly use WebGL/Three.js (2025's Lando Norris site and "Messenger"), but SOTDs and honorable mentions are won regularly by minimal, non-WebGL, solo-built sites. For Tigon, editorial craft + restrained GSAP/Framer motion is the right, achievable target. Don't over-scope.
- **Trend tension:** some 2026 commentary argues for "tactile maximalism" (rich texture, editorial density) *against* minimalism, while other strong commentary argues minimalism is making a "violent comeback" as the anti-AI move. Both agree on the real point: **have a distinct point of view**. Pick a lane and commit; the failure mode is the safe, opinion-less middle. `(Ariel Digital)` `(Xdcweb)`
- **Specific hex/px values here are starting points, not gospel** — perceived size and contrast vary by typeface (Neue Montreal at 16px reads differently than Inter at 16px), so validate the scale and contrast in-browser against WCAG.
- **Sourcing note on easing values:** the confirmed canonical curves (`easeOutExpo (0.16, 1, 0.3, 1)`; `easeOutQuint (0.22, 1, 0.36, 1)`) come from easings.net and Material Design 3's published tokens; the specific "strong ease-out" `(0.23, 1, 0.32, 1)`, the "under

300ms / 180ms feels more responsive than 400ms" rule, and the "built-in CSS easings too weak" position are attributed to Emil Kowalski's published motion teaching (animations.dev). A legacy Penner table lists slightly different quint/expo values — use the easings.net values.